▼ GLASSHOUSE



BREWING AMBITION

While neighbouring Bihar still battles prohibition, Uttar Pradesh is making the most of its excise potential. On February 12, the Yogi Adityanath government rolled out its first standalone three-year excise export policy to place 'Made in UP' bottles on global shelves. Duties, export pass fees, franchise charges and special levies have been slashed for export-designated tipples. Brand registration and label approvals have been eased, and fees on foreign liquor, beer and wine waived. The aim is clear: turn India's top excise revenue-earner into a liquor export hub. UP's current share of national exports is about 11 per cent, but riding on the India-EU trade agreement, the state hopes to plant 'Brand UP' firmly in Europe. The only question: will the world acquire a taste for UP's brew?

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ FACTION WARS IN MP

PEACE BROKER

Though long seen as a lightweight choice, Madhya Pradesh BJP president **Hemant Khandelwal** has now begun asserting himself. His current focus: healing the many factional rifts in the state. This includes minister Govind Singh and ex-minister Bhupendra Singh, who are locked in a feud in the Bundelkhand region. In Indore, local leaders are pitting themselves against



Kailash Vijayvargiya's towering presence. In Rewa, caste politics has led to local leaders closing ranks against deputy CM Rajendra Shukla. Khandelwal has now convened meetings of the various factions and urged CM Mohan Yadav to visit rival constituencies to signal that they "matter". Such visits have already taken place in Sagar, Rewa and Indore. If the disputes ease up, Khandelwal's stature could rise sharply.